sight.

One such moment occurs here, on the cold and secret journey to Kabul. Every night, the travellers would stop at a friendly home; and, one night, the lamp in their room burnt out. Immediately, the child-prince burst into howls of protest. His ‘nurses did their best [but] they could not . . . [soothe] him’; only the light of a fresh lamp stopped his tears. In Abul Fazl’s telling, this is, of course, a sign of Akbar’s supernatural origins; he was a Niru’un after all, descendant of Alanqoa and pure light – but it is easy enough to see him two years old, far from home, wide awake as the wind blows and grown-ups confer in low tones. It is easy enough to see a small child, afraid of the dark.

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If Askari had been a fond though unreliable uncle, Kamran was his sinister counterpart. Far from trying to make his little nephew smile, Kamran ‘cringed’ – says Abul Fazl – when he met Akbar.[24] To make matters worse, Kamran had brought along a painted drum – not for Akbar, but for his own son, Ibrahim, who was a little older than his cousin. As soon as Akbar saw the drum, however, he wanted it. Kamran was not inclined to indulge his nephew, of course, but he thought he might get a little fun out of the situation. He made the drum a prize and told the boys to wrestle for it.

Akbar wasn’t daunted by the idea of fighting the older, bigger Ibrahim; he was delighted. The podgy little toddler ‘girt up his loins, and rolled up his sleeves . . . and stepped bravely forward’.[25] Soon, Ibrahim was flat on the ground, the spectators had erupted in cheers, and Kamran had stormed away. Later, his anger would give way to spite: Kamran ordered that Akbar be weaned; his fond mamas would no longer be allowed to suckle him.

If Kamran was cold and mean-spirited, however, there was another in Kabul whose love for Akbar overflowed. This was his great-aunt Khanzada Begum, Babur’s older sister, trusted adviser to and intermediary between his squabbling sons. Khanzada was given charge of Akbar when he arrived in the city, and was immediately besotted by her grand-nephew. As Gulbadan describes it, the elderly lady would kiss Akbar’s hands and feet, exclaiming, ‘They are the very hands and feet of my brother [Babur], and he is like him altogether.’